SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #37 · LIFE-STAGE PRESSURES

“Caring for others means my needs don't count.”

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Where it often comes from

Parents, caregivers for aging relatives, and people in helping professions often learn to put themselves last. Family messages like “Don’t be selfish” or religious teaching that confuses sacrifice with self-erasure can add to it. Over time, we may stop noticing our own needs, grow tired and resentful, and still feel guilty for wanting anything.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said the second great commandment is to love our neighbor as ourselves, which assumes that we also care for ourselves. Paul says no one ever hated his own body, but nourishes and cherishes it. Paul also says to look not only to our own interests, but also to the interests of others, which means both. When Elijah was exhausted, God let him sleep and sent an angel to say, “Get up and eat.” Caring for ourselves is not selfish. It is how we keep loving others.

> *“And the second is like it: ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’”* (Matthew 22:39).

Also see

> “Indeed, no one ever hated his own body, but he nourishes and cherishes it, just as Christ does the church” (Ephesians 5:29).

> “Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others” (Philippians 2:4).

> “Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, ‘Get up and eat.’” (1 Kings 19:5).

> “He makes me lie down in green pastures; He leads me beside quiet waters” (Psalm 23:2).

Common self-statements

- My needs are not important.
- Taking time for myself is selfish.
- Everyone else comes first.
- If I stop, everything will fall apart.
- I should not need anything.
- Good people do not have needs.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must always put others first.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I must either serve others or be selfish.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I am wrong to rest.
- Magnification: Treating a short break as a failure of love.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that my needs do not count?
- What would happen to the people I love if I became exhausted or ill?
- What does “love your neighbor as yourself” say about how I treat myself?
- What do I need most right now?

- Who could share some of the load?
- What is one small way I can care for myself this week?

Truth summary

> My needs count to God, and caring for myself helps me keep loving others. I can care for the people in my life without erasing myself and can ask for help without guilt.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Sacrifice
- Tired
- Servant
- Help
- Love, For Others

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Caring for others means my needs don't count"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Caring for others means my needs don't count." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn that my needs do not count?
- ☐ What do I need right now?
- ☐ Who could share the load?
- ☐ What happens if I run out of strength?
- ☐ What is one small act of self-care?
- ☐ How can I ask for help this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My needs matter to God.
- ☐ Love your neighbor as yourself includes me.
- ☐ Rest helps me love well.
- ☐ I can ask for help.
- ☐ Self-care is not selfishness.
- ☐ I can care for others and for myself.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Matthew 22:39
  "And the second is like it: 'Love your neighbor as yourself.'"
- ☐ Ephesians 5:29
  "Indeed, no one ever hated his own body, but he nourishes and cherishes it, just as Christ does the church."
- ☐ 1 Kings 19:5
  "Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, 'Get up and eat.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] One need met: Each day, name one need you had and one small way you met it or asked for help.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Matthew 22:39 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can love my neighbor as myself, so my needs matter too.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Sacrifice" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] List your needs. Write physical, emotional, and spiritual needs you have been ignoring.
- [ ] Ask for help. Choose one task to hand off to someone else this week.
- [ ] Schedule a recharge. Put a block of rest or enjoyment on the calendar.
- [ ] Pray Matthew 22:39. Ask God to show you how to love yourself as He does.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Caring for others means my needs don't count": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A need I honored
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Caring for others means my needs don't count.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You care for the one who cares for others. Forgive me for ignoring my needs. Show me how to love my neighbor and myself, and give me the grace to ask for help. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.